

DATA CARD: AFRICAN FOLKTALES SLM DATASET

Team Name: Ethiopie

Project Focus: Cultural Preservation and Creative Narration via Small Language Models (SLMs)

1. Input vs. Output

- **Model Inputs:**
 - **Text Prompts:** Narrative openings, character descriptions, cultural motifs, or specific regional settings provided by users (e.g., "Write a story about Anansi set in a coastal village").
 - **Contextual Tokens:** Regional, linguistic, or structural tags used to condition the style and flow of the output text.
- **Model Outputs:**
 - **Generative Text:** Highly coherent, contextually authentic African folktales generated in natural language.
 - **Narrative Flow:** Text structures that natively replicate traditional African oral storytelling formats (such as call-and-response cues, recurring structural moral loops, rhythmic proverbs, and community-centric dialogue).

2. Classification Task

- **Classification Setup:** While primarily a generative text model, the system uses internal **multi-label classification tokens** to structure narrative context effectively.
- **Categories/Classes Utilised:**
 - *Geographic/Regional Origin:* West African, East African, Southern African, North African, Central African.
 - *Thematic Archetypes:* Trickster tales, Origin myths, Moral/Didactic fables, Historical legends.
 - *Narrative Device Tags:* Proverb insertion points, Call-and-response markers, Dialect stylistic weightings.

- **Rationale for Selection:** These classification tags prevent the model from homogenising diverse cultures into a single "generic African" style. They guarantee that a West African trickster story preserves its unique structural and cultural markers, while staying distinct from a Southern African origin myth.

3. Labelling Strategy

- **Source of Labels:**
 - **Community Elders & Local Storytellers:** Primary source for authentic structural and contextual verification.
 - **Domain Experts:** Cultural anthropologists, African literature scholars, and local historians from regional universities.
- **Label Quality and Consistency Controls:**
 - *Consensus Adjudication:* Implementation of a multi-reviewer verification framework where every story profile requires verification from at least two local language or cultural experts.
 - *Inter-Rater Reliability Testing:* Running structured consistency audits across annotators to align regional dialect tags, vocabulary, and moral themes.
 - *Rejection Thresholds:* Any source document or translation flagged as highly Westernised, heavily distorted by historical bias, or culturally misattributed will be completely dropped from the training set.

4. Data Creation

- **Direct Sourcing Framework:** Fieldwork recordings of oral histories, community-led audio transcripts, and direct text contributions submitted by local storytellers.
- **Archival and Published Sourcing:** Accessing and indexing translated anthropological archives, out-of-copyright African literature collections, and regional library repositories.
- **Low-Resource Data Synthesis Strategy:**
 - To address data scarcity without losing cultural depth, Team Ethopie will use **back-translation methodologies**. Stories written in indigenous languages

will be translated into English/French and back again to expand linguistic variations.

- Using rule-based templates modeled explicitly on authentic oral syntax to expand training context safely without relying on generic, biased synthetic generation engines.

5. Web Collection Ethics

- **Targeted Platforms:** Publicly available open archives, digital libraries, and cultural heritage databases managed by African universities or regional non-governmental organizations (NGOs).
- **Consent & Copyright Compliance:**
 - Prioritising public domain historical records and texts explicitly released under Creative Commons licensing models.
 - Strict adherence to robots.txt files, API usage terms, and digital data collection boundaries.
- **Privacy & Indigenous Data Sovereignty Constraints:**
 - *Strict Anonymization:* Full removal of personally identifiable information (PII) belonging to contemporary community contributors, narrators, or field researchers.
 - *Respect for Sacred Practices:* Complete exclusion of sacred, restricted, or closed community knowledge that was never intended for public distribution or global commercial usage.

6. Bias and Representation

- **Underrepresented Groups Identified:** Minoritized language groups, localized regional dialects, and remote communities whose stories were never formally cataloged by Western anthropologists or standard internet scrapers.
- **Mitigation and Fairness Plan:**
 - *Balancing Dataset Weights:* Implementing stratifying data balances to prevent a handful of widely documented stories (e.g., Anansi the Spider fables) from drowning out lesser-known localized regional mythologies.

- *Inclusive Language Ingestion*: Actively incorporating localized African English, French, and Portuguese pidgins/creoles alongside indigenous languages to preserve natural, modern colloquial storytelling.
- *Continuous Bias Audits*: Regular evaluations of model checkpoints using targeted validation sets to catch and strip out recurring Western narrative tropes, harmful stereotypes, or historical colonial distortions.

7. Values and Community Alignment

- **Alignment with Challenge 1 Values**: This dataset is purposefully designed to break free from standard global data extraction dynamics. It explicitly centers local agency, technological sovereignty, and exact cultural accuracy as its primary metrics.
- **Tangible Community Benefits**:
 - Provides schools and local cultural centers with an interactive digital archive to keep oral storytelling traditions accessible to younger generations.
 - Demonstrates a working blueprint showing that lightweight, purpose-built Small Language Models (SLMs) can outperform generic, massive LLMs when dealing with localized, culturally sensitive data.
- **Accountability Protocols**:
 - Establishing a **Community Review Board** made up of local educators, writers, and cultural guardians. This board holds complete veto power over model distributions and dataset updates if any generation output is found to disrespect, exploit, or misrepresent their shared cultural heritage.